

Mediterranean Meze Bar

Sharing plates. Exceptional margins. The Mediterranean way.

36	\$42	22%	\$19.4K
SEATS	AVG SPEND	FOOD COST	EST. MONTHLY NET

Chef's Lens

// WHAT A MICHELIN-TRAINED CHEF SEES IN MEDITERRANEAN MEZE

The Mediterranean meze tradition understands something about eating that single-plate dining

ignores: that the act of sharing food changes the experience of eating it. Meze is not a starter. It is a format — one that produces higher average spends, longer dwell times and stronger repeat visit rates than almost any other casual dining model. The food costs are exceptional because the foundation is plant-based: hummus, baba ghanoush and labneh cost less to produce than any protein dish, and all three improve significantly after 24 hours in the fridge. The cold meze advantage is operational gold: your highest-selling items are made the night before, your morning prep is restocking, and your kitchen is calm before service.

// WHAT THIS GUIDE DOES

The Mediterranean diet is the most researched, most validated dietary pattern in the world. Your customers already believe in it. Your job is to execute it properly — olive oil that is genuinely good, bread that is baked the same day, octopus that has been through the freeze-thaw tenderising cycle and hit the grill at the right temperature. When readers reach the financial model, the response is consistent: the margins on plant-forward meze are better than they expected.

They are. This guide shows you exactly why.

Key Performance Indicators

36

SEATS

\$42

AVG SPEND /
COVER

22%

FOOD COST
TARGET

\$19,400

EST. MONTHLY
NET

Entrées — Cold & Hot Meze

Classic Hummus — Whole & Fried Chickpeas

SERVICE: 4 min | FOOD COST: 11% | ALLERGENS: Sesame (tahini)

- 1 Blend soaked chickpeas with tahini, lemon juice, garlic and ice water until ultra-smooth. Rest overnight in fridge — texture improves dramatically.
- 2 To serve: swirl hummus in bowl, drizzle with high-quality EV00, scatter whole chickpeas and 3–4 fried crispy chickpeas on top.
- 3 Finish with sumac and paprika. Serve with warm flatbread.

The overnight rest is non-negotiable. Garlic mellows, lemon integrates, texture silks out. Never serve day-of hummus.

Baba Ghanoush

SERVICE: 3 min | FOOD COST: 13% | ALLERGENS: Sesame (tahini)

- 1 Char whole aubergines directly over open flame until fully collapsed and smoky — **skin blackened all over**. This is the flavour.
- 2 Scoop flesh, drain excess liquid 15 min, fold in tahini, lemon, garlic, salt. Do not over-blend — texture should be slightly rough.
- 3 Serve with EVOO, pomegranate seeds, fresh parsley.

Gas flame > grill. The carbonisation of the skin is what creates the smokiness that makes baba ghanoush taste like baba ghanoush.

Labneh — Strained Yogurt

SERVICE: 3 min | FOOD COST: 10% | ALLERGENS: Dairy

- 1 Strain full-fat yogurt through muslin for 24–48 hours in the fridge. Salt lightly before straining.
- 2 Plate in a shallow bowl, drizzle generously with EVOO, dust with za'atar or dried mint.
- 3 Serve with crudités or warm pita. Can be rolled into balls and stored in olive oil for extended shelf life.

10% food cost. This is your highest-margin cold meze. Push it as a table opener — it sells itself.

Falafel — Crispy Herb

SERVICE: 7 min | FOOD COST: 14% | ALLERGENS: Gluten

- 1 Soak raw (not canned) chickpeas 12 hours. Blend with parsley, coriander, cumin, garlic, onion — do not over-process. Mix should be coarse.
- 2 Rest mix 30 min, form balls, fry at **175°C** for 3–4 minutes until deep golden. Do not crowd the fryer.
- 3 Serve immediately — falafel must be eaten hot. Accompaniments: tahini sauce, pickled turnip, fresh herbs.

Canned chickpeas produce wet, dense falafel that falls apart in oil. Raw and soaked only. Non-negotiable.

Spanakopita — Spinach & Feta Triangles

SERVICE: 8 min | FOOD COST: 16% | ALLERGENS: Gluten, Dairy, Eggs

- 1 Wilt and fully drain spinach — squeeze out every drop of moisture or the filo will become soggy.
- 2 Mix with crumbled feta, egg, dill, nutmeg. Fold into buttered filo triangles, seal edges with egg wash.
- 3 Bake at **190°C** until golden and crisp — approx 18 min. Reheat orders: 4 min in hot oven. Never microwave.

Lamb Kofta — Grilled, Tahini & Pomegranate

SERVICE: 10 min | FOOD COST: 19% | ALLERGENS: None

- 1 Mix ground lamb (20% fat) with grated onion, parsley, cumin, cinnamon, allspice, salt. Knead 5 min to develop binding.
- 2 Shape onto flat skewers, press firmly. Grill over high heat — **charcoal preferred** — 4 min each side.
- 3 Rest 2 min. Drizzle tahini sauce, scatter pomegranate seeds and fresh mint. Serve with flatbread.

Lamb fat content is critical. Under 20% and the kofta dries out on the grill. Source from a butcher who understands the ratio.

Mains — Part I

Shakshuka — Eggs in Spiced Tomato Signature

SERVICE: 12 min | FOOD COST: 15%

- 1 Base: sweat onion and red pepper in EVOO, add garlic, cumin, paprika, harissa. Add crushed tomatoes. Simmer 20 min. This base is made in bulk each morning — holds 3 days.
- 2 To order: heat base in cast iron pan, create 3 wells, crack eggs in. Cover and cook until whites set but yolks remain runny — approx **8-10 min at medium**.
- 3 Finish with crumbled feta, fresh coriander, EVOO drizzle. Serve in the cast iron with warm bread alongside.

The cast iron goes to the table. Theatre matters. Customers photograph it. That's earned marketing.

Grilled Halloumi Plate

SERVICE: 8 min | FOOD COST: 18% | ALLERGENS: Dairy

- 1 Slice halloumi 1cm thick. Pat dry — moisture prevents caramelisation. Brush with EVOO.
- 2 Grill on very hot griddle pan — **high heat, no moving** — 2 min per side until deep char marks appear and cheese softens.
- 3 Serve immediately on a bed of dressed rocket with watermelon, mint and a honey-lemon drizzle. Halloumi must be served hot — it becomes rubbery cold.

Slow-Braised Lamb Shoulder Signature

SERVICE: 5 min (6hr braise) | FOOD COST: 24%

- 1 Into oven at 08:00 every morning. Rubbed with garlic, rosemary, cumin, cinnamon, EVOO. Placed over sliced onions, stock and wine. Sealed with foil.
- 2 Braise at **160°C for 6 hours**. Remove foil last 30 min to caramelize the exterior.
- 3 To serve: pull meat from bone, plate over roasted root vegetables, spoon braising jus. Garnish with gremolata and pomegranate.

At 24% FC this is your highest cost main — but it justifies premium pricing and drives repeat visits. The 6-hour story sells it. Your servers know the story (see service scripts).

Mezze Platter for Two — 8 Cold Dishes Signature

SERVICE: 6 min | FOOD COST: 20%

- 1 Assemble on large slate or wood board: hummus, baba ghanoush, labneh, tabbouleh, olives, dolmades (2), stuffed peppers, pickled turnip.
- 2 Each component kept prepped and portioned in the cold section. Assembly is a presentation task, not a cooking task — speed is achievable.
- 3 Accompany with warm flatbreads (3), lemon wedge, fresh herbs. Present to the table as a single board.

Highest dollar-value item, 6-minute ticket time, no live cooking required. This is the model dish. Push it hard.

Mains — Part II

Chicken Shawarma Plate

SERVICE: 10 min | FOOD COST: 19%

- 1 Marinate chicken thighs minimum 24h: yogurt, lemon, garlic, cumin, coriander, turmeric, cinnamon, cardamom, EVOO. Thighs only — breast dries out.
- 2 Roast at **220°C for 25 min** or grill on vertical spit. Slice thin against the grain.
- 3 Serve over saffron rice with garlic sauce (toum), pickled turnip, fresh tomato-parsley salad, tahini.

Grilled Whole Sea Bream

SERVICE: 14 min | FOOD COST: 23%

- 1 Score fish 3 times each side. Season cavity with lemon, garlic, fresh herbs. Brush skin with EVOO, season aggressively with sea salt.
- 2 Grill on very hot grill — **do not touch for 6 min**. Skin will release naturally when ready. Flip once. Total 12 min for 400g fish.
- 3 Serve whole on the plate — this is Mediterranean, not a filleted piece. Accompaniments: chargrilled lemon, fresh herbs, EVOO, roasted cherry tomatoes.

At 14 min ticket, this is your longest-firing main. Take the order before the table is fully settled if they express interest early.

Moussaka — Lamb & Béchamel

SERVICE: 12 min | FOOD COST: 21% | ALLERGENS: Gluten, Dairy, Eggs

- 1 Made in trays: layers of roasted aubergine, spiced lamb mince (cinnamon, allspice, tomato), topped with thick béchamel.
- 2 Baked until top is golden — **180°C, 45 min**. Rested and cut into portions. Reheated to order in oven 10 min.
- 3 Serve with Greek salad alongside and crusty bread. A scattering of grated kefalotiri cheese on the béchamel before service.

Fattoush Salad — Crisp Bread, Sumac

SERVICE: 5 min | FOOD COST: 12%

- 1 Tear day-old pita into pieces, toast or fry until very crisp. These can be prepped in bulk each morning.
- 2 Toss with tomato, cucumber, radish, spring onion, fresh mint, parsley. Dress with sumac-pomegranate molasses vinaigrette.
- 3 Add bread last, toss lightly — pita goes in at service to retain crunch. Serve immediately.

Dolmades — Stuffed Vine Leaves

SERVICE: 5 min | FOOD COST: 14%

- 1 Rice filling: short-grain rice with dill, mint, lemon zest, pine nuts, currants, EVOO. Blanch vine leaves 1 min, shock in ice water.
- 2 Roll tightly, pack into pot with lemon slices and EVOO. Braise gently **1 hour** until rice cooked through and leaves tender.
- 3 Serve 5–6 per portion at room temperature with tzatziki and lemon wedge.

Vegetarian Mezze Bowl Vegan

SERVICE: 6 min | FOOD COST: 13%

- 1 Base of saffron-scented couscous or bulgur wheat. Top with 5 components: hummus, roasted vegetables, tabbouleh, olives, pickled turnip.
- 2 Drizzle with herbed EVOO and lemon. Scatter toasted pine nuts and fresh herbs.
- 3 Serve with warm flatbread. All components prepped — assembly only. Flag as vegan on menu with clear icon.

13% food cost, 6 min ticket, vegan-certified. This dish sells to the fastest-growing dining demographic. Price it accordingly — do not undercharge.

Desserts

Baklava — Pistachio & Honey

SERVICE: 3 min | FOOD COST: 14% | ALLERGENS: Gluten, Nuts

- 1 Layer buttered filo with crushed pistachio and walnut mix (2:1 ratio). Bake at **170°C until deep golden** — approx 35 min. Cut into diamonds immediately after baking.
- 2 Soak in honey-sugar syrup with rose water and orange blossom while hot. Allow to absorb fully — minimum 2 hours, overnight preferred.
- 3 Serve 2 pieces per portion at room temperature with a scattering of crushed pistachios. Pair with Turkish coffee (see service scripts).

Made in bulk, holds 5 days at room temperature, 3 min service. One of the best margin desserts in any cuisine.

Knafeh — Shredded Pastry, Cheese, Orange Blossom

SERVICE: 6 min | FOOD COST: 16% | ALLERGENS: Gluten, Dairy

- 1 Press buttered kataifi pastry into base of pan. Layer with sweet cheese filling (akkawi or mozzarella, desalted). Top with more kataifi.
- 2 Bake at **190°C for 20 min** until golden. Must be served hot — the cheese pull is the experience.
- 3 Invert onto plate, soak in orange blossom syrup. Dust with crushed pistachios. Serve immediately.

Knafeh cannot be held. Fire to order. The 6-minute ticket is honest. Warn the table it is coming hot.

Loukoumades — Greek Honey Doughnuts

SERVICE: 7 min | FOOD COST: 11% | ALLERGENS: Gluten, Dairy

- 1 Yeast batter: flour, water, yeast, salt. Allow to prove until doubled. Batter should be loose and bubbly — not a dough.
- 2 Fry teaspoon-sized drops in **180°C oil** until puffed and golden all over — about 3 min. They will rotate naturally as one side browns.
- 3 Drain, pile in bowl, drizzle with honey, dust with cinnamon, scatter sesame seeds and chopped walnuts. Serve instantly.

Halva with Pistachio & Rose

SERVICE: 2 min | FOOD COST: 8%

- 1 Source high-quality tahini-based halva. Slice 2cm-thick portions with a warm knife for clean

edges.

- 2 Plate on a small slate with a scattering of crushed pistachios, dried rose petals and a drizzle of honey.
- 3 Accompaniments: fresh mint, lemon wedge. Pairs with Turkish coffee or mint tea.

8% food cost, 2 min service. Halva is the perfect late-night dessert upsell — light, not heavy, makes the bill feel worthwhile.

Drinks Menu

Ayran — Salted Yogurt Drink

\$4.99

Traditional cold yogurt drink. Salted, not sweet. Pairs with everything spiced.

Lebanese Arak — Anise Spirit

\$10.99 / glass

Served with water and ice. Turns milky white when mixed. Table ritual.

Mint Lemonade

\$5.99

Fresh-pressed, blended with whole mint. Made to order. High perceived value.

Turkish Coffee

\$4.99

Prepared in cezve. Ask sweet, medium or unsweetened at order. Pair with baklava.

Pomegranate Juice

\$6.99

Cold-pressed, no sugar added. Deep colour, high visual appeal on the table.

Arak & Meze Welcome Set

\$14.99

Arak glass + olives + flatbread. Best table opener. Push to every party of 2+.

House White Wine — Greek Assyrtiko

\$12.99 / glass

Crisp, mineral, high acid. Perfect with seafood and cold meze. From Santorini.

Sparkling Water — Efes

\$3.99

Turkish mineral water. Strong carbonation. Cleanses palate between dishes.

Always offer the Arak & Meze Welcome Set on arrival — it sets the tone, increases average spend and begins the mezze narrative before the menu is even opened.

Service Scripts

These are not scripts to memorise verbatim. They are the ideas your team must understand deeply enough to say naturally. Authenticity beats recitation every time.

// WELCOME + DRINK CHOICE

"We start every table with a welcome drink — either the arak, which is anise and water, or the ayran, which is cold salted yogurt. Both are traditional. Your choice."

// MEZZE RHYTHM EXPLANATION

"The mezze comes in waves — cold dishes first, then the hot. Don't wait for everything to arrive before starting. That's not how mezze works."

// LAMB SHOULDER TIMING

"The lamb has been in the oven since 8am. Six hours. It's been basting in its own fat and spices the whole time. When it falls off the bone, it's ready."

// BAKLAVA + TURKISH COFFEE PAIRING

"The baklava is best with the Turkish coffee — the bitterness cuts through the honey and pistachio. That's how it's eaten in Istanbul."

// RETURN VISIT

"Thursday nights we do a mezze feast — \$45 per person, 12 dishes, shared. Different experience. Worth coming back for."

Prep Schedule

Time	Task	Notes
07:00	Cold mezze prep	Hummus, baba, labneh improve overnight — check and refresh
08:00	Lamb shoulder into oven	6-hour braise begins. No exceptions on timing.

09:00	Falafel mix prep	Raw chickpeas blended fresh. Rest 30 min before forming.
10:00	Baklava assembly	Cut, syrup-soak today's portion. Pre-made holds 5 days.
11:00	Shakshuka base prep	Bulk base for service. Holds 3 days refrigerated.
12:00	Lunch service opens	All cold sections stocked. Hot sections at temperature.
15:00	Reset	Restock, clean, prep for dinner. Brief team debrief.
17:00	Second lamb batch	Fresh shoulder for dinner service. Into oven now.
18:30	Dinner service opens	Full team, all stations live.
22:30	Close	Cold prep for next day. Overnight rest begins.

Financial Model — P&L Overview

\$2,520 DAILY REVENUE	\$15,120 WEEKLY REVENUE	\$65,520 MONTHLY REVENUE	\$22,932 MONTHLY NET (~35%)
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Line Item	% of Revenue	Monthly (\$)
Gross Revenue	100%	\$65,520
Food Cost	22%	\$14,414
Labour	28%	\$18,346
Overheads	15%	\$9,828
Net Profit	~35%	\$22,932

Mediterranean meze achieves 22% food cost because the highest-volume items — hummus, baba ghanoush, labneh, dolmades — are plant-based and prep-forward. The model rewards operational discipline, not complicated cooking.

Food Cost by Category

Dish	Category	Food Cost %	Service Time
Halva with Pistachio & Rose	Dessert	8%	2 min
Labneh	Entrée	10%	3 min
Classic Hummus	Entrée	11%	4 min
Fattoush Salad	Main	12%	5 min
Vegetarian Mezze Bowl	Main	13%	6 min
Baba Ghanoush	Entrée	13%	3 min
Baklava	Dessert	14%	3 min

Falafel	Entrée	14%	7 min
Dolmades	Main	14%	5 min
Shakshuka	Main	15%	12 min
Knafeh	Dessert	16%	6 min
Spanakopita	Entrée	16%	8 min
Grilled Halloumi Plate	Main	18%	8 min
Chicken Shawarma	Main	19%	10 min
Lamb Kofta	Entrée	19%	10 min
Mezze Platter for Two	Main	20%	6 min
Moussaka	Main	21%	12 min
Grilled Whole Sea Bream	Main	23%	14 min
Slow-Braised Lamb Shoulder	Main	24%	5 min service

Allergen Reference

Staff must be able to recite allergen information for every dish without referring to a menu. This is a legal and ethical responsibility.

Allergen Matrix

Dish	Allergens
Classic Hummus	Sesame (tahini)
Baba Ghanoush	Sesame (tahini)
Labneh	Dairy
Falafel	Gluten
Spanakopita	Gluten Dairy Eggs
Lamb Kofta	None declared
Baklava	Gluten Nuts
Knafeh	Gluten Dairy
Moussaka	Gluten Dairy Eggs
	Gluten Dairy

Loukoumades

Gluten

Dairy

⚠ Always check with the kitchen for dish modifications. Cross-contamination risk exists in a shared kitchen environment. When in doubt, escalate to the chef on duty.

Full Menu Summary

Section	Count	Avg FC	Avg Ticket
Entrées	6 dishes	~13.8%	~6 min
Mains	10 dishes	~18.9%	~8.8 min
Desserts	4 dishes	~12.3%	~4.5 min
Drinks	8 items	—	—

// THE MODEL IN SUMMARY

The Mediterranean Meze Bar is built on a foundation that is genuinely unusual in casual dining: its highest-volume, highest-frequency items are also its lowest cost-to-produce items. Hummus, baba ghanoush and labneh improve in the fridge overnight, require no live cooking, and sell at significant margins. The prep-forward, share-format model compresses kitchen labour during service while increasing average covers and dwell time. When the financial model works at 22% food cost across 20 dishes spanning proteins, seafood and plant-based formats — that is not luck. That is the Mediterranean kitchen working exactly as it was designed to work. Your job is to execute it with integrity.

Run it right. The numbers will follow.